Claude in Emacs: Cheat Sheet

Custom commands for running and editing Claude Code sessions inside Emacs vterm buffers. Claude sessions are named `claude-<name>`; plain terminals are `vterm-<name>`.

Starting and restarting a session

Keys	What it does	When to use
`C-c c n`	**New named session** in its own frame (`claude-<name>`). Prompts for a name, pins a session id, logs it to the registry.	Your default. Always start this way so sessions are recoverable by name.
`C-c c r`	**Reopen a past session by name** (tab-complete from the registry), via `claude --resume`.	After a crash or quit, to bring a session back. The one you will actually use.
`C-c c R`	Resume the **most recent** conversation (`claude --continue`), in the current window.	Rarely useful when many sessions are running.
`C-c c c`	New session in the current window, **unnamed and not registered**.	Rarely. The bare, old way.
`C-c t`	Named plain (non-Claude) terminal in a new frame.	Any ordinary shell work.

Editing and sending input to Claude

Keys	What it does
`C-c e`	In a `claude-*` buffer: open `*claude-compose*`, a real text buffer with full Emacs editing (transpose, kill-ring, spellcheck, and so on).
`C-c C-c`	In the compose buffer: send the text to the session (bracketed paste, keeps newlines) and submit.
`C-c C-k`	In the compose buffer: cancel without sending.
`C-c C-v`	Enter `vterm-copy-mode`: read-only, navigate, search, and copy the output like a normal buffer. Press `q` to exit.

Copy and paste inside a session

Keys	What it does
`M-c`	Copy (kill-ring-save)
`M-v`	Paste (vterm-aware yank)
`M-x`	Cut (kill-region)
`M-l`	Run an Emacs command (`execute-extended-command`)

Mnemonics and notes

- The `c` prefix means Claude: **n**ew, lowercase **r** to **r**eopen a named session (the common one), capital **R** for **R**ecent (`claude --continue`, rarely used), and the standalone `e` for **e**dit/compose.
- The live Claude prompt is a terminal, so keystrokes go straight to Claude and Emacs editing cannot touch that line in place. Use `C-c e` (compose buffer) for real Emacs editing.
- The session registry lives at `~/.claude/vterm-sessions.tsv` (one line per named session: name, id, directory, timestamp).
- After a crash, sessions started with `C-c c n` come back by name via `C-c c r`. Sessions started the bare way are recoverable only by grepping `~/.claude/projects/`.